

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF NEW YORK

-----X
ABRECA BURTON,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK; POLICE OFFICER
GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027); NYPD
OFFICERS JOHN and JANE DOE 1 through 10, (the
names John and Jane Doe being fictitious, as the true
names are presently unknown),

Defendants.

-----X

SUMMONS

Jury Trial Demanded

Plaintiff designates NEW
YORK County as the place
of trial.

The basis of venue is:
CPLR § 504(3)

To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorney within 20 days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the Complaint.

Dated: New York, New York
June 18, 2024

Anna Berezovski

Anna Berezovski
Of Counsel to
THE LAW OFFICE OF
KATHERINE E. SMITH
233 Broadway, Ste. 900
New York, New York 10279
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Attorney for Plaintiff

TO:

ZACHARY W. CARTER
Corporation Counsel of the CITY of New York
Attorney for Defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027)
1st Precinct
16 Ericsson Place
New York, NY 10013

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COMPLAINT

Jury Trial Demanded

Index No.

BASIS FOR VENUE:

CPLR § 504(3)

PLAINTIFF ABRECA BURTON, by PLAINTIFF's attorney, Anna Berezovski, Esq, and THE LAW OFFICE OF KATHERINE E. SMITH, P.C., complaining of the defendants, respectfully alleges as follows:

PARTIES

1. PLAINTIFF ABRECA BURTON was and is a female and has been at all relevant times a resident of Queens County in the CITY and State of New York.

2. Defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, was and is a municipal corporation duly organized and existing under and by virtue of the laws of the State of New York.

3. Defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, maintains the New York CITY Police Department ("NYPD"), duly authorized public authorities and/or police departments, authorized to perform all functions of a police department as per the applicable sections of the New York State Criminal Procedure Law, acting under the direction and supervision of the aforementioned municipal corporation, The CITY of New York. The NYPD is responsible for the appointment,

training, supervision, promotion and discipline of officers and supervisory security officers and staff, including the individually named defendants herein.

4. At all times relevant defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD No. 25027), and NYPD Defendants John & Jane Doe 1 through 10 (“DOE Defendants”) were police officers, detectives or supervisors employed by the NYPD. PLAINTIFF does not know the real names and shield / tax numbers of defendants John & Jane Doe 1 through 10.

5. That at all times hereinafter mentioned the defendants, either personally or through their employees, were acting under color of state law and/or in compliance with the official rules, regulations, laws, statutes, customs, usages and/or practices of the State or CITY of New York.

6. Each and all of the acts of the defendants alleged herein were done by said defendants while acting within the scope of their employment by defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

7. Each and all of the acts of the defendants alleged herein were done by said defendants while acting in furtherance of their employment by defendant THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

8. Plaintiff has complied with all conditions precedent to suit.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

9. On or about December 7, 2022, at or around 4:21 pm, PLAINTIFF was lawfully within the vicinity of Green Street and Prince Street, in the County and State of New York, when several unidentified New York City Police Officers, including defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027), and the DOE Defendants (collectively "defendants"), approached PLAINTIFF and unlawfully searched PLAINTIFF and the above mentioned vicinity, falsely arrested, falsely imprisoned, assaulted and battered, used excessive force upon, subjected

PLAINTIFF to malicious abuse of process, malicious prosecution, denial of access to a fair trial, inter alia.

10. Specifically, on the above date and time, PLAINTIFF was lawfully driving at the above mentioned vicinity when the defendants NYPD officers, including defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027), and the DOE Defendants unlawfully stopped and searched PLAINTIFF, and the vehicle in which PLAINTIFF was within despite the fact that they had no reasonable suspicion or other lawful basis to do so.

11. Defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027), and the DOE Defendants recovered no contraband from PLAINTIFF's person or from within the vehicle.

12. Notwithstanding the fact that defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027), and the DOE Defendants lacked probable cause or reasonable suspicion to believe that PLAINTIFF had committed any crimes or offenses, defendants officers placed PLAINTIFF into handcuffs and under arrest.

13. In so doing, defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027), and the DOE Defendants, without cause, used excessive force and otherwise assaulted and battered PLAINTIFF. Specifically, the defendants applied excessively tight handcuffs, which caused injuries to PLAINTIFF's wrists.

14. PLAINTIFF was subsequently transported to the police precinct. At the precinct, the officers falsely informed employees of the New York County District Attorney's Office ("DA's office") that they had observed PLAINTIFF commit various crimes/offenses. Neither PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO. 25027) nor the DOE Defendants observed PLAINTIFF violate any laws/ordinances.

15. The allegations made by defendants PO GIOVANNI INSUASTI (SHIELD NO.

25027), and the DOE Defendants to the DA's office were false, and the defendants knew them to be false at the time the defendants made the allegations. The defendants then forwarded these false allegations to the DA's office in order to justify the unlawful arrest of PLAINTIFF and to persuade the DA's office to commence and/or continue the criminal prosecution of PLAINTIFF.

16. The defendants knew and understood that the DA's office was relying on the truthfulness of defendants' claims and statements in order to evaluate whether to commence a criminal prosecution against the PLAINTIFF. Defendants were aware that the DA's office assumed that all of the factual statements, claims and allegations that defendants relayed to the DA's office were truthful in all material respects.

17. From the precinct, PLAINTIFF was then transported to central booking and was subsequently arraigned. PLAINTIFF remained in custody for an extended period of time prior to arraignment.

18. PLAINTIFF appeared in court as required and PLAINTIFF's criminal case was subsequently dismissed in its entirety on December 8, 2022.

19. PLAINTIFF suffered damage as a result of defendants' actions. PLAINTIFF was deprived of liberty, suffered physical, emotional, and mental trauma, emotional distress, mental anguish, fear, pain, bodily injuries, anxiety, shock, embarrassment, humiliation, and reputational damage.

CLAIM ONE
Under State and Federal Law
UNREASONABLE FORCE

20. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

21. The defendants violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments and New York

State Law because they used unreasonable, excessive, and unjustified force on PLAINTIFF.

22. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

CLAIM TWO
Under State Law
NEGLIGENCE

23. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

24. Defendant CITY of New York for the oversight of its agents, servants, and/or employees, who include officials and staff at NYC NYPD, including the individually named defendants and DOE Defendants.

25. Furthermore, the CITY is liable for damages caused by the negligent or wrongful acts of its agents, servants, and/or employees acting within the scope of their employment.

26. NYPD officials and staff have a duty to protect the civilian population in general, and PLAINTIFF in particular.

27. Defendants, including CITY and the individually named defendants breached their duty to protect the PLAINTIFF from harm by failing to take any actions to protect PLAINTIFF.

28. As a result of these actions and inactions by the NYPD officers, including the individually named defendants and DOE Defendants, PLAINTIFF suffered and is still experiencing pain and permanent injuries, shock, fright and loss of freedom.

CLAIM THREE
Under State Law
ASSAULT and BATTERY

29. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth

herein.

30. The individual defendants placed a mark on PLAINTIFF, which directly placed PLAINTIFF in apprehension of imminent harmful and offensive bodily contact.

31. Defendants' aforementioned actions caused PLAINTIFF to be subjected to unauthorized physical contact that resulted in injury.

32. Defendant NYPD officers did so without privilege or consent from PLAINTIFF.

33. As a result of defendants' conduct, PLAINTIFF suffered physical pain and mental anguish, together with shock, fright, apprehension, embarrassment, and humiliation.

CLAIM FOUR
Under State Law
INTENTIONAL INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS

34. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

35. The aforementioned conduct was extreme and outrageous, and exceeded all reasonable bounds of decency.

36. The aforementioned conduct was committed by the Individual Defendants while acting within the scope of their employment by defendant CITY.

37. The aforementioned conduct was committed by Individual Defendants while acting in furtherance of their employment by defendant CITY.

38. The Defendant employer CITY is responsible for the wrongdoings of their employees and agents under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

39. The aforementioned conduct was intentional and done for the sole purpose of causing severe emotional distress to PLAINTIFF.

40. As a result of these actions and inactions of the Defendants, PLAINTIFF suffered damages alleged herein.

CLAIM FIVE
Under State Law
NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS

41. PLAINTIFF repeat and reallege each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

42. By reason of the foregoing, each Defendant was negligent in committing conduct that inflicted emotional distress upon PLAINTIFF.

43. The negligent infliction of emotional distress by these Defendants was unnecessary and unwarranted in the performance of their duties.

44. Defendants, their officers, agents, servants, and employees were responsible for the negligent infliction of emotional distress upon PLAINTIFF.

45. The Defendant employer CITY is responsible for the wrongdoings of their employees and agents under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

46. As a direct and proximate result of the misconduct and abuse of authority detailed above, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

CLAIM SIX
Under Federal Law
DELIBERATE INDIFFERENCE TO SAFETY/MEDICAL NEEDS

47. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

48. The Individual Defendants were aware of a risk to PLAINTIFF's safety and a need for medical care and failed to act in deliberate indifference to PLAINTIFF's needs.

49. Specifically, they knew of a specific threat to her safety and refused to address that threat, ignored that threat, and as a result PLAINTIFF was injured.

50. Accordingly, defendants violated the Fourth, Fourteenth, and Eighth amendments because they acted with deliberate indifference to PLAINTIFF's medical needs and safety.

51. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

CLAIM SEVEN
Under Federal Law
FAILURE TO INTERVENE

52. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

53. Those defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct and failed to intervene.

54. Accordingly, the defendants who failed to intervene violated the First, Fourth, Fifth And Fourteenth Amendments.

55. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

56. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

CLAIM EIGHT
Under Federal Law
DEPRIVATION OF FEDERAL RIGHTS

57. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

58. All of the aforementioned acts of defendants, their agents, servants and employees, were carried out under the color of state law.

59. All of the aforementioned acts deprived PLAINTIFF of the rights, privileges and immunities guaranteed to citizens of the United States by the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States of America, and in violation of 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

60. The acts complained of were carried out by the aforementioned individual defendants in their capacities as NYPD officers with all the actual and/or apparent authority attendant thereto.

61. The acts complained of were carried out by the aforementioned individual defendants in their capacities as NYPD officers, pursuant to the customs, usages, practices, procedures, and the rules of the CITY of New York, the New York Police Department, and the all under the supervision of ranking officers of said department.

62. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct which constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure or rule of the respective municipality/authority, which is forbidden by the Constitution of the United States.

CLAIM NINE
Under State Law
NEGLIGENT HIRING/TRAINING/SUPERVISION/RETENTION

63. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

64. Defendant CITY OF NEW YORK selected, hired, trained, retained, assigned and supervised all members of its Police Department, including the defendants individually named above.

65. Defendant CITY OF NEW YORK was negligent and careless when it selected, hired, trained, retained, assigned, and supervised all members of its Police Department, including the defendants individually named above.

66. Due to the negligence of the defendants as set forth above, PLAINTIFF suffered physical and mental injury, pain and trauma, together with embarrassment, humiliation, shock, fright, and loss of freedom.

CLAIM TEN
Under Federal Law
MUNICIPAL LIABILITY

67. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

68. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct that constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure or rule of the respective municipality/authority, which is forbidden by the Constitution of the United States.

69. The aforementioned customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York, New York City Police Department, but are not limited to, the following unconstitutional practices:

- i. arresting individuals regardless of probable cause in order to inflate the officer's arrest statistics; and,
- ii. arresting innocent persons notwithstanding the existence of credible evidence which exonerates the accused of any criminal wrongdoing; and,
- iii. fabricating evidence in connection with their prosecution in order to cover up police misconduct; and,
- iv. fabricating evidence in connection with search warrants in order to effectuate otherwise illegal searches and seizures; and,
- v. fabricating evidence in connection with search warrants in order to cover up police misconduct.

70. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York, New York City Police Department, constituted deliberate indifference to the safety, well-being and constitutional rights of the PLAINTIFF.

71. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York, New York City Police Department, were the direct and proximate cause of the constitutional violations suffered by the PLAINTIFF as alleged herein.

72. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York, New York City Police Department, were the moving force behind the constitutional violations suffered by the PLAINTIFF as alleged herein.

73. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, were directly and actively involved in violating the PLAINTIFF's constitutional rights.

74. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, acquiesced in a pattern of unconstitutional conduct by subordinate NYPD officers, and were directly responsible for the violation of the PLAINTIFF's constitutional rights.

75. The acts complained of deprived the PLAINTIFF of her right:

- A. Not to be deprived of liberty without due process of law;
- B. To be free from seizure and arrest not based upon probable cause;
- C. Not to have summary punishment imposed upon her; and
- D. To receive equal protection under the law.

CLAIM ELEVEN

Under N.Y.C. ADMIN. CODE §§ 8-801 TO 8-807

76. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

77. Plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures was violated by the conduct of the Individual Defendants.

78. The CITY of New York is liable as the employer of the Individual Defendants under New York CITY Administrative Code § 8-803(b).

79. Qualified immunity is no defense to this claim.

80. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

81. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

CLAIM TWELVE
Under State and Federal Law
UNLAWFUL STOP, SEARCH, AND SEIZURE

82. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

83. As a result of the aforesaid conduct by defendants, PLAINTIFF's person and possessions were illegally and improperly seized and searched without consent, a valid warrant, probable cause, privilege or consent, in violation of his constitutional rights as set forth in the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

CLAIM THIRTEEN
Under State and Federal Law
FALSE ARREST

84. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

85. Defendant police officers arrested PLAINTIFF in the absence of probable cause and without a valid warrant.

86. As a result of the aforesaid conduct by defendants, PLAINTIFF was subjected to an illegal, improper and false arrest by the defendants and caused to be falsely imprisoned, detained and confined. The aforesaid actions by the defendants constituted a deprivation of the PLAINTIFF's rights.

CLAIM FOURTEEN
Under State and Federal Law
MALICIOUS ABUSE OF PROCESS

87. PLAINTIFF repeats and re-alleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

88. The individual defendants issued legal process to place PLAINTIFF under arrest.

89. The Municipal Defendants arrested PLAINTIFF in order to obtain collateral objectives outside the legitimate ends of the legal process.

90. The Municipal Defendants acted with intent to do harm to PLAINTIFF without excuse or justification.

91. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, PLAINTIFF sustained, *inter alia*, loss of liberty, loss of earnings, emotional distress, mental anguish, shock, fright, apprehension, embarrassment, humiliation, deprivation of constitutional rights, in addition to the damages hereinbefore alleged.

CLAIM FIFTEEN
Under State and Federal Law
MALICIOUS PROSECUTION

92. PLAINTIFF repeats and realleges each and every allegation as if fully set forth herein.

93. By their conduct, as described herein, defendants are liable to PLAINTIFF for having committed malicious prosecution under the laws of the State of New York.

94. Defendants maliciously commenced criminal proceeding against PLAINTIFF, falsely accusing PLAINTIFF of violating the law.

95. Defendants falsely and without probable cause charged PLAINTIFF with violations of the laws of the State of New York.

96. The commencement and continuation of the criminal proceedings against PLAINTIFF was malicious and without probable cause.

97. All charges were terminated in PLAINTIFF's favor.

98. Defendants, their officers, agents, servants and employees were responsible for the malicious prosecution of PLAINTIFF. Defendant CITY of New York, as an employer of the individual defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

99. As a direct and proximate result of the misconduct and abuse of authority stated above, PLAINTIFF sustained the damages alleged herein.

CLAIM SIXTEEN
Under Federal Law
DENIAL OF CONSTITUTIONAL RIGHT TO FAIR TRIAL

100. PLAINTIFF repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the preceding paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

101. Defendants created false evidence against PLAINTIFF.

102. Defendants forwarded false evidence and false information to prosecutors in the District Attorney's office.

103. Defendants misled the prosecutors by creating false evidence against PLAINTIFF and thereafter providing false testimony throughout the criminal proceedings.

104. In creating false evidence against PLAINTIFF, in forwarding false evidence and information to prosecutors, and in providing false and misleading sworn statements, defendants violated PLAINTIFF's constitutional right to a fair trial under the Sixth Amendment and the Due Process Clause of the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

105. As a result of the foregoing, PLAINTIFF's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, was put in fear for PLAINTIFF'S safety, and was humiliated and subjected to handcuffing and other physical restraints without probable cause.

WHEREFORE, PLAINTIFF respectfully requests judgment against defendants as follows:

- i. an order awarding compensatory damages in an amount to be determined at trial;
- ii. an order awarding punitive damages in an amount to be determined at trial;
- iii. reasonable attorneys' fees and costs under 42 U.S.C. § 1988; and
- iv. directing such other and further relief as the Court may deem just and proper, together with attorneys' fees, interest, costs and disbursements of this action.

DATED: New York, New York
June 18, 2024

Anna Berezovski

Anna Berezovski
Of Counsel to
THE LAW OFFICE OF
KATHERINE E. SMITH
233 Broadway, Ste. 900
New York, New York 10279
Tel/ Fax: 347-470-3707
anna@legalsmithny.com
Attorney for Plaintiff

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

ANNA BEREZOVSKI, an attorney duly admitted to practice law in the Courts of the State of New York, shows:

I am *of Counsel* to THE LAW OFFICE OF KATHERINE E. SMITH, PC, attorneys for PLAINTIFF ABRECA BURTON, in the within entitled action.

That your deponent has read the foregoing **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and knows the contents thereof, and that the same is true to her own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters, she believes it to be true.

That the source of the deponent's information is investigation and records in the file.

The reason why the verification is made by the deponent and not by the PLAINTIFF is that the PLAINTIFF is not within the county wherein the deponent maintains her office.

I affirm this 18th day of June 2024, under the penalties of perjury under the laws of the State of New York, which may include a fine or imprisonment under penalty of perjury, that the foregoing is true and correct, and I understand that this document may be filed in an action or proceeding in a court of law.

Dated: New York, New York
June 18, 2024

Anna Berezovski

Anna Berezovski